THIRD ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

IN 1670 England's King Charles II made a secret alliance with France's King Louis XIV to attack the Dutch Republic. A declaration of war was delayed until April 1672, giving Lieutenant Admiral Michiel de Ruyter time to train the Dutch fleet in disciplined battle tactics. The combination of the English fleet and the French navy, recently strengthened and expanded by Louis's chief minister Colbert, gave the allies an overwhelming superiority of numbers. But they cooperated poorly and quarrels disrupted their naval operations. De Ruyter fought an inspired campaign with inadequate resources, tempering aggression with a necessary concern to preserve his fleet. He came under political attack at home after his friend Johan de Witt was expelled from office and lynched by a mob, but at sea his performance was impeccable. His successes in defensive battles at Scheveningen and Texel led to recriminations between the allies and fueled anti-war feeling in England, where the alliance with Catholic France was deeply unpopular. Under pressure from his own people, King Charles made peace with the Dutch in 1674.

THIRD ANGLO-DUTCH WAR



THE BATTLE OF SOLEBAY

Date	June 7,1672
Location	Off Southwold, eastern England
Result	Dutch victory

COMBATANTS

ENGLAND	**DUTCH REPUBLIC**
FRANCE	

COMMANDERS

Duke of York, Comte d'Estrées	**Michiel de Ruyter**

FORCES

Ships: English: 63 French: 30	**Ships:** 75

LOSSES

Ships: 1	**Ships:** 3

THE BATTLE OF SOLEBAY

At the outset of the war, the Dutch planned to attack the English fleet before it could join with its French allies, but they delayed too long. By early June 1672 the allied fleets, under the overall command of King Charles's brother James, Duke of York, had met up and were anchored in Solebay, careening hulls and taking on supplies. They heavily outnumbered the Dutch, but de Ruyter decided to attack, with the advantage of surprise and an onshore wind behind him.

At 2.30 on the morning of June 7, a French frigate reported sighting the Dutch approaching Solebay. The allies were totally unprepared, moored in no particular order, and with many sailors sleeping ashore. Ships hastily made ready for battle and strove to get out to sea against the breeze. Whether through a misunderstanding or a deliberate decision, the Comte d'Estrées, in command of the French fleet, steered to the south, despite a signal from the Duke of York to follow him northward. The allied line was thus split in two. De Ruyter detached the 15 ships of his rear squadron to keep d'Estrées' 30 ships occupied in a long-range duel, while his center and van went for the English fleet, now deprived of their numerical advantage.



Battle of Solebay medal
This French medal depicts a horse-drawn Neptune threatening Holland with his

Putting to sea in haste, the English ships were spread out in a ragged formation, and thus poorly placed to support one another. The Dutch concentrated on attacking the English flagships, easily identifiable by their array of large ensigns. The Duke of York's *Royal Prince* was engaged at close range by de Ruyter's flagship *Zeven Provincien* and the 76-gun *Eendracht*. The power of *Royal Prince*'s guns kept the Dutch at bay, but after two hours' battering the Duke was forced to shift his flag from the crippled ship. A worse fate befell *Royal James*, the 100-gun flagship of the Earl of Sandwich. She was grappled by the 60-gun *Groot Hollandia*, which raked her with broadsides point blank until she was disabled. The Earl refused to strike his colors, and got away from the panic to abandon the blazing vessel, the Earl of Sandwich was drowned, his body washing ashore a few weeks later, identifiable only by his Order of the Garter. The Dutch had also suffered losses and toward nightfall de Ruyter broke off the engagement.

Friesland
This model of the Dutch second-rater *Friesland* shows the shallow draft characteristic of Dutch warships. It was needed for sailing in Holland's coastal waters.

End in fire
Dutch and English sailors shoot at each other with pistols as men-of-war engage with broadsides. To the right, *Royal James* burns after a Dutch fireship attack.